

the people of Richmond were thrown into a state of panic by the approach of a Union naval squadron, including two ironclads, up the James River on which the city stands.

“You may find **those who will go faster than I**, Mr. President; but it is **very doubtful** if you will find **many who will go further.**”

GENERAL GEORGE B. McCLELLAN, IN A LETTER TO LINCOLN AFTER HIS REMOVAL FROM COMMAND, NOVEMBER 1862

Fight for the capital

Plans were made by the Confederates to abandon Richmond, but on May 15, a combination of shore batteries and underwater obstacles blocked the passage of the Union squadron at Drewry's Bluff. Despite this reprieve, Richmond's defenses could not be expected to hold out under prolonged bombardment by Union siege guns, which were now being brought up to the front. Offensive action was required to drive back McClellan's army.

Union engineers had bridged the Chickahominy, and two corps, made up of about a third of McClellan's 100,000 troops, had crossed the river. Johnston planned to isolate and overwhelm these corps while the rest of the Union army stayed north of the river. It was not a bad plan for an army with inferior numbers taking on a stronger enemy, for in principle the Confederates would gain local superiority. Heavy rain on the eve of the battle—known as Fair Oaks or Seven Pines—made the river a raging torrent. But the execution of the Southern attack on the morning of May 31 was chaotic. Confused and contradictory orders meant that units blocked one another in their advance. Union soldiers were driven back, but late in the afternoon reinforcements began to arrive from the other